defecation is a major cause of spreading diseases like cholera, dysentery and diarrhoea, as well as exposing women and girls to sexual assaults. As part of his flagship Clean India Mission, Modi promised to provide all Indian citizens with access to toilets, and between 2014 and 2020 the Indian state invested around ten billion dollars in the project, building more than 100 million new latrines.[33] Sewage isn't the stuff of epic poems, but it is a test of a well-functioning state.

THE BIOLOGICAL DRAMAS

Mythology and bureaucracy are the twin pillars of every large-scale society. Yet while mythology tends to inspire fascination, bureaucracy tends to inspire suspicion. Despite the services they provide, even beneficial bureaucracies often fail to win the public's trust. For many people, the very word 'bureaucracy' carries negative connotations. This is because it is inherently difficult to know whether a bureaucratic system is beneficial or malicious. For all bureaucracies – good or bad – share one key characteristic: it is hard for humans to understand them.

Any kid can tell the difference between a friend and a bully. You know if someone shares their lunch with you or instead takes yours. But when the tax collector comes to take a cut from your earnings, how can you tell whether it goes to build a new public sewage system or a new private dacha for the president? It is hard to get all the relevant information, and even harder to interpret it. It is similarly difficult for citizens to understand the bureaucratic procedures determining how pupils are admitted to schools, how patients are treated in hospitals or how garbage is collected and recycled. It takes a minute to tweet allegations of bias, fraud or corruption, and many weeks of arduous work to prove or disprove them.

Documents, archives, forms, licences, regulations and other bureaucratic procedures have changed the way information flows in society, and with it the way power works. This made it far more difficult to understand power. What is happening behind the closed doors of offices and archives, where anonymous officials analyze and organise piles of documents and determine our fate with a stroke of a pen or a click of a mouse?

In tribal societies that lack written documents and bureaucracies, the human network is composed of only human-to-human and human-to-story